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Dear Hiring Manager,

I am applying for the Knowledge Paralegal role in A&O Shearman's Global Financial Markets Group. My interest in financial markets work developed from a specific point. At the A&O Shearman open day in August 2026, a session on private equity transactions and a workshop on lender security, including examples involving aircraft and ship financing, gave me a concrete picture of how legal work shapes market practice at the transactional level. I followed that up by completing a Coursera course on private equity, studying fund structures, leverage and exit strategies, because I wanted to understand the commercial mechanics that sit behind the legal documentation. That progression is why a knowledge-focused role in GFM is the right next step for me, not a generic ambition.

My research and writing skills have been tested in contexts that translate directly to knowledge work. At BCLP, across a year-long placement in international arbitration and real estate disputes, I drafted procedural histories, amended sections of a claimant's memorial and prepared procedural orders. I also conducted legal and factual research on easements, leasehold issues and rights of light, writing up findings in a form the fee-earner could use immediately. At Q-Legal, I produced a formal written advice letter on UK GDPR obligations for a data-driven start-up, translating statutory requirements into commercially focused guidance under a solicitor's supervision. Both roles required me to frame legal analysis clearly for a specific audience rather than reproduce the law in the abstract.

Organising and maintaining structured materials under pressure is something I have done consistently. At BCLP I became the sole junior supporting an arbitration team shortly before a significant submission deadline, coordinating documents, tracking outstanding actions and helping ensure on-time filing. At Citizens Advice I now manage matters from instruction to submission, maintaining confidential case records and meeting deadlines across a varied caseload. I understand that knowledge work depends on that same discipline applied to resources and outputs the wider team relies on.

A&O Shearman is where the interest started, and this role is a direct extension of that.

Yours sincerely,
Maria Silva